

Nonprofit Registration Checklist

Want to start a nonprofit? The path to official 501(c)(3) status is a clear set of steps — and you can do most of it yourself. Below is the checklist with official resources. Tick the box once you've done each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

You do NOT need to pay a company thousands to start a nonprofit — the IRS and your state let you do it directly. If your group is small, a “fiscal sponsor” can even let you operate under another nonprofit’s status first.

1 Build the Foundation

Set up the legal bones of your nonprofit.

☐ Define Mission & Recruit a Board

Write a clear mission and recruit a board of directors (most states require at least 3).

→ www.councilofnonprofits.org/running-nonprofit/governance-leadership/board-roles-and-responsibilities

☐ Incorporate in Your State

File articles of incorporation with your state, and create bylaws. SBA links to your state office.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/launch-your-business/register-your-business

2 Get Your Federal IDs

You need an EIN and then tax-exempt status from the IRS.

☐ Get an EIN — Free From the IRS

Your nonprofit’s federal tax ID. Always free at IRS.gov.

→ www.irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed/apply-for-an-employer-identification-number-ein-online

☐ Apply for 501(c)(3) Status

File IRS Form 1023 (or the shorter, cheaper 1023-EZ if you qualify) to become tax-exempt.

→ www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/applying-for-tax-exempt-status

3 Register to Operate & Fundraise

A few more registrations keep you legal and able to raise money.

☐ Register for Charitable Solicitation

Most states require nonprofits to register before fundraising. Check your state’s rules.

→ www.councilofnonprofits.org/running-nonprofit/fundraising-and-resource-development/charitable-solicitation-registration

☐ Open a Nonprofit Bank Account

Once incorporated with an EIN, open a dedicated bank account to keep finances clean.

→ **Open after incorporation & EIN**

4 Get Free Help

Experienced advisors guide you through the whole process.

☐ SCORE — Nonprofit Mentoring

Free mentors who've started nonprofits before.

→ www.score.org

☐ National Council of Nonprofits

Free, trusted guidance for every step of starting and running a nonprofit.

→ www.councilofnonprofits.org

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Companies charge \$1,000–\$3,000 to do paperwork you can file yourself for under \$300 in fees. The IRS Form 1023-EZ is short and inexpensive if you qualify — check before paying anyone.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

If you're testing an idea, consider a "fiscal sponsor" — an existing 501(c)(3) that lets you operate under their status. It's faster and cheaper than full incorporation while you get started.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national steps. For your state's exact incorporation and fundraising rules, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll point you to the right offices.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
